



Audio Reporting 101

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Who is this guy?

- Newspapers
 - 2001 - 2003 – Meriden Record-Journal
 - 2003 - 2009 – Hartford Courant
- Radio
 - 2010 – 2022 – Connecticut Public Radio
 - 2022 – present – WBUR



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What will we cover?

- How do I get sound?
- What is good sound?
- How do I turn good sound into a story?



How do I get sound?

- It doesn't need to be intimidating.
- Using your laptop
 - Zoom
- Using a handheld recorder
 - Your phone
 - A fancier recorder



How do I get sound?

- Technique
 - Listen
 - Make sure you're recording
 - Get close
 - Don't interrupt
 - Mic/cable noise
 - Levels
 - Stop and start
 - Room tone/ambi
 - Listen for changes (ex: refrigerator hum)
 - What they're saying vs. how they're saying it



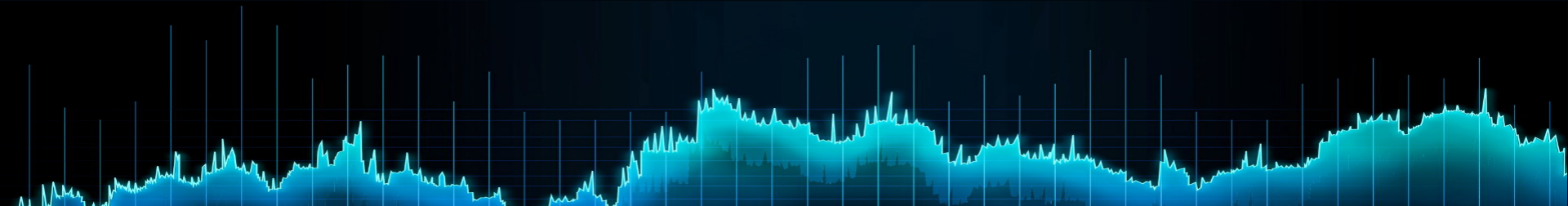
What is good sound?

- Get a scene
 - Use sound to take me there
 - Sound isn't background. It's not a gimmick.
 - Sound is motion, activity, humans, feeling, place.
 - Show, don't tell with your sound



What is good sound?

- Set a scene
 - Bring to me a place.
 - Introduce me to humans.
 - Use the sound to tell me why I should care.
 - Just as with an anecdotal lede, use your scene to set the stage/summarize what's to come.



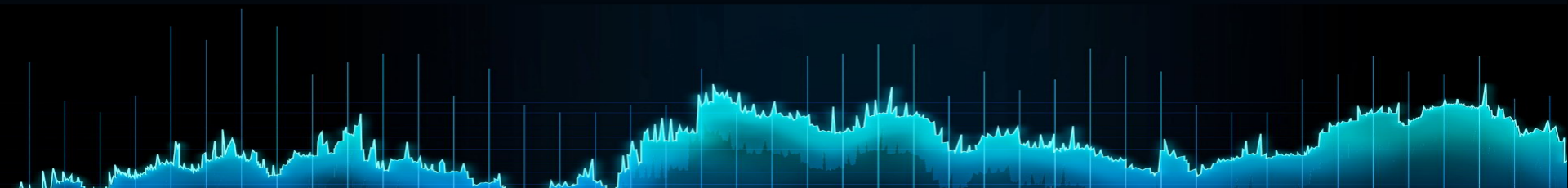
How do I write for broadcast?

- You are writing for **listeners**, not **readers**.
 - Keep it simple
 - Think about your audience, not your sources.
 - You can't use everything in your notebook.
 - You can't use the bottom of your story as a dumpster.
 - Tape is rarely, rarely longer than 20 or 25 seconds.



Examples

- Lots of talking, no descriptive scene. Does it work?
- Winemaking. (I had to write the scene here, because I didn't have very much active sound.)
- A profile. (You can also maybe hear how I grew more confident in my voicing over time.)
- Shameless self promotion.



Reach out!

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